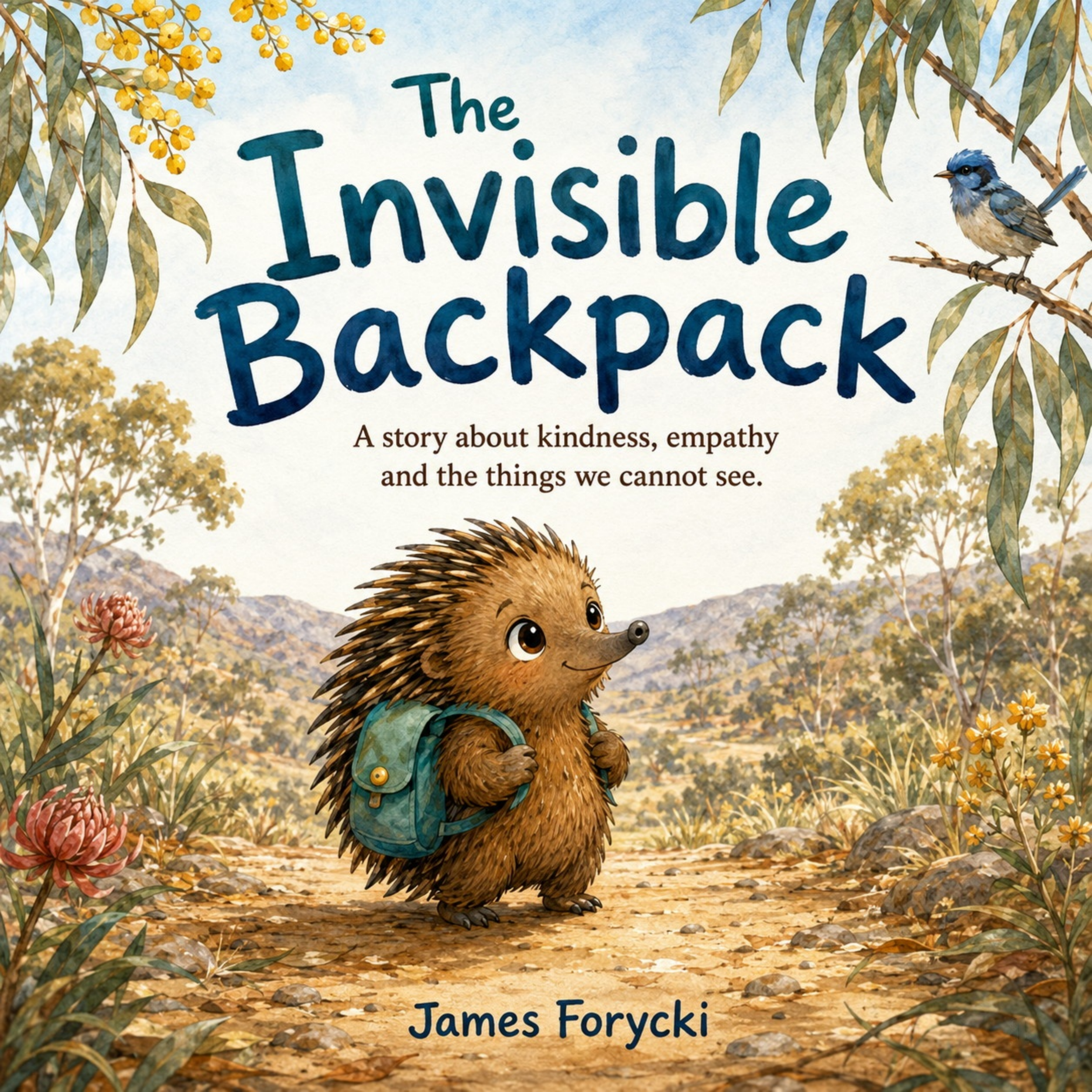




The Invisible Backpack

A story about kindness, empathy
and the things we cannot see.

James Forycki



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The Invisible Backpack

Written by James Forycki





For every little heart
carrying big feelings.

In a warm little forest
lived a tiny echidna named Pip.



Pip noticed things
others sometimes missed.



One morning,
all the animals walked
to the clearing.



Kangaroo bounced.
Koala wandered.
Wombat shuffled.
Birdie fluttered.



Then Pip noticed
something strange.



Everyone was
carrying a backpack.



Not a backpack
you could touch.



A hedgehog with brown spines and a blue backpack stands on a dirt path, looking up at a magical display. The display features four backpacks in different colors (yellow, blue, green, and purple) floating within swirling, ethereal bands of light. The scene is decorated with hearts, stars, butterflies, and a small blue mouse. The background includes a tree with yellow leaves and a field of yellow flowers.

These backpacks
were invisible.

Kangaroo's backpack
looked light.
She laughed and leaped.



Birdie's backpack looked tiny.
He sang sweet songs.



But Koala's backpack
looked very heavy.



A detailed illustration of a koala sitting on the ground at the base of a large gum tree. The koala is grey with a black nose and large, fluffy ears, looking down with a sad expression. It is sitting with its arms crossed over its knees. To its right is a blue backpack with a yellow bell. The ground is covered in brown leaves and small yellow flowers. In the background, there are more trees and a hazy landscape under a bright sky. The text is written in a simple, black, serif font to the left of the koala.

Koala sat alone under the gum tree.
He did not climb.
He did not play.

Pip asked softly,
'Are you okay, Koala?'



‘I think so,’ said Koala.
But his voice sounded small.



At lunch, Wombat dropped his berries.
They rolled into the dirt.



Pip helped pick them up,
one by one.



“Thank you,” whispered Wombat.

And just like that,
his backpack looked
a little lighter.



Pip blinked.

“Kindness makes backpacks
lighter,” he whispered
to himself.



ARTWORK PENDING

Page 23 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

**Near the river, Birdie sat quietly on a branch.
He was not singing.**

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration
brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 24 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

"Why aren't you singing today?" asked Pip.

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 25 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

**Birdie looked at his little feet. "Yesterday
someone laughed when I sang the wrong
note."**

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration
brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 26 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

Pip climbed onto a rock below him. "I like your song," said Pip. "Even the wobbly parts."

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 27 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

**Birdie looked surprised. Then he sang one
tiny note. Tweet.**

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration
brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 28 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

Pip felt something warm grow inside his chest. Maybe helping did not have to be big.

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 29 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

Then Pip saw Kangaroo. She was bouncing higher than anyone. Boing. Boing. Boing.

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

ARTWORK PENDING

Page 30 — approved text shown below, illustration not yet created

"You're amazing!" called Birdie. "You're so brave!" said Wombat. Kangaroo's smile was a little too bright.

See PROJECT_CHECKPOINT.md for the full illustration brief (characters, expressions, style) for this page.

For Parents & Teachers

Discussion & Connection

- What is something you might keep in an invisible backpack?
- How can you tell if someone's backpack is heavy?
- What can you do to help someone feel lighter?
- How did Pip help his friends?
- When do you feel most like Pip?



Small acts of kindness can make a big difference.





We may not see
what someone is carrying,
but we can always
choose to be kind.